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Glacial Grieving: Melting the Ice Within to See the World Renewed

Sarah D. Norton

Later in his life, Carl Gustav Jung became increasingly interested in the alchemical process as a symbolic representation of the individuation journey. By focusing on the stages of the *nigredo* and the *albedo*, this paper expands upon the importance of these steps in the psychological process of individuation. Jung (1970a) wrote that individuation “gathers the world to oneself” rather than shutting one out from the world (p. 136). This is an aspect of the journey toward wholeness that is especially relevant in our current era of climate crisis.

By exploring the *nigredo* and the *albedo* deeply, we can begin to see the many shades of blue that lie underneath. These blues, and the idea of feeling blue, offer a pathway to empathy and understanding through our shared grief. With a careful examination of *The Red Book: Liber Novus* (Jung, 2009), after a time of traumatic ambiguous loss, and amplified with the images of ice in our warming world, this paper takes a paradoxical journey. From the blues of the Arctic ice to the bright red of *Liber Novus*, this black and white path becomes illuminated with a variety of colors. This expanded, empathetic view of the complex image of ice brings with it the gift of the *rubedo*, a renewed hope born out of death, grief, and chaos.

Individuation does not shut one out from the world, but gathers the world to oneself.

—Jung (1970a, p. 136)

In our current era of climate crisis, we have sadly accomplished a *nigredo* no one wished to achieve. We are, as a worldwide society, teetering on the brink of the irreversible. I do not say this to instill a sense of inevitability or despair, but rather to show that there is still a chance for hope. This hope may not be a familiar path; it may not be one that we ever considered hopeful before the novel moment in which we find ourselves embroiled currently; but it is hope nonetheless.

Whether you have been aware of the environmental degradation that faces our planet for decades or mere weeks, the weight of this issue is one that is difficult to bear. Indeed, many prefer to deny, mitigate, or ignore the psychological stress that this reality brings. Once we learn the facts of our warming world, we are thrust into the darkness of what this information means. The realization of inevitable change, and possible chaos, throws us from the bright light of understanding and scientific data into the depths of not-knowing. Only here, in the womb of the underworld, can we begin to



Mask, Yup'ik, Native American, Alaska, ca. 1900. Wood, pigment, vegetal fiber, iron nails, and feathers, 34.5 × 22 × 9.5 in. Courtesy of the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. The Charles and Valerie Diker Collection of Native American Art, Gift of Valerie-Charles Diker Fund, 2017 Accession Number: 2017.718.3.

develop what is needed now and have our mettle, our figurative metal, tested in the alchemical crucible of the *nigredo*.

THE ALCHEMICAL VESSEL

In his essay, “The Seduction of Black,” archetypal psychologist James Hillman (1997) wrote, “the *nigredo* is not the beginning, but an accomplished stage” (p. 47). He reminds us that we are only here in this darkness, this stage of blackness of the *nigredo*, because something has been achieved. In our current situation, this can refer to the years of neglect and endless growth that humanity has valued above and beyond people or planet. In a more personal, psychological sense, we are only able to recognize that we have reached the *nigredo* by increasing our awareness. At some point, things start to fall apart, as they must, before they can come back together. When we reach these moments of chaos, the *nigredo* has been achieved, consciously or not.

For the analytical psychologist Carl Gustav Jung (1875–1961), this time of chaos came in a period that he termed his “confrontation with the unconscious” (Jung, 1989, pp. 170–199). This time, from 1913 to 1930, led him to journal *The Black Books* (Jung, 2020) and then to create *The Red Book* (Jung, 2009), both published posthumously. Later in his life, Jung became interested in alchemy as a symbolic representation of the psychic process that he termed *individuation*. In the alchemical texts, Jung recognized a parallel journey to the one he undertook in those early years of “confrontation.” Individuation, according to Jung, was the continual practice of bringing the contents of the unconscious into relationship with consciousness.

For the alchemists this was represented by the transmutation of lead, or some other dark ore, into gold. There are differing views on whether these experiments were purely physical experiments (the beginning of modern chemistry), purely psychological, or merely illustrative journaling or philosophical musings. The truth is that no single explanation is sufficient. Alchemy was not either/or, but rather, it was both/and. In this exploration of the alchemical process, two of the stages find themselves paired together often: the *nigredo* and the *albedo*, the stages of darkening and enlightening.

The Arctic, too, is a place of darkness and light. It is an alchemical vessel in its own right. In a very literal sense, this place, at the top of the world, has months of daylight in the summer and months of night in the winter. It is a place of dark ocean waters and white ice and snow. It is also a place of vast exploration throughout history, each of these resulting in not only rich learning and treasure, but deep devastation and loss. More figuratively, it is a place of mystery and the unknown, but also a place that has carried many bright projections upon its snowy surface. This area on some medieval maps was simply referred to as *Thule*. The etymology of this word is shrouded in mystery, but could be connected to the Gothic *tiule*, meaning “most remote land,” or to the Greek *telos*, meaning “the end,” presumably the end of the world or the end of exploration to that point.

No matter its exact meaning, the general idea is the same: it was an area that was remote and unknown. Even in our modern world, the Arctic realms continue to carry this meaning forward. Deep in the Arctic and Antarctic ice, scientists remove ice cores to unlock the mystery of our world’s climate. Now that the ice has begun to melt, not only are we at risk of losing precious data from eons past, but we are also finally discovering the truth of what happened to ill-fated ships and explorers. Given the mysteriousness of these landscapes, these frozen realms are a fitting symbol of the unconscious. Much like thick forests, the depths of the oceans, and the vastness of outer space, they

have managed to hold secrets even beyond the technological wonders of our modern society. How much longer will that be the case? No one can say for certain.



Figure 1. Photograph from a glacier hike on Solheim Glacier in Southern Iceland. *View from a Melting Glacier*, by Sarah D. Norton, 2015.

REACHING THE NIGREDO

For the alchemists, the *nigredo* was often symbolized by lead, or another dark metal, before it was heated or dissolved in an attempt to elicit the precious silver or gold they imagined within. The *nigredo* is the alchemical process of blackening. In a psychological reading, this stage is a symbol of unconscious contents before they are brought into consciousness. Throughout Jung and Shamdasani's (2009) *The Red Book: Liber Novus*, there is image after image of these unconscious contents, both beautiful and terrifying. Within the pages of *The Red Book*, Jung laboriously and calligraphically transcribed and painted the images that presented themselves to him during his "confrontation with the unconscious."

Today, with the publication of Jung's (2020) *The Black Books*, we can truly glimpse the *nigredo* process in action. In these newly published volumes, we see Jung's process of active imagination played out in the dark depths of his soul before they take on a more palatable form in the pages of *The Red Book*. However, these more refined images still carry the unconscious forward. *The Red Book* is an inspiring dive into these depths, and a useful example of the creative process of active imagination.

LIKE FRESHLY FALLEN SNOW

When I received my copy of *The Red Book* for Christmas in 2009, I could not wait to open that cumbersome tome, to hear the spine crack open, and begin exploring the

illuminated pages within. The paintings sparked my imagination before I even began to read, as I am sure others experienced as well. These colorful, symbolic expressions drew the reader in and made one wonder, made the mind wander, and caused the imagination to spring to life. In those initial days sitting with the images of *The Red Book*, I encountered each page with the wide eyes of a child. With each turn, it was like waking up on Christmas morning to the bright shine of a newly fallen snow—each page a glimmering gift for my own projections and musings. Even without reading the text, the images came alive in a rainbow of possibilities. This is the beauty of art and images: each of us can view the same painting, but not one of us will see it in the same light. This is the power of the archetypal.

Jung wrote that archetypes are “like riverbeds which dry up when the water deserts them, but which it can find again at any time” (Jung, 1970b, p. 189). In the snowy white landscape of my wandering imagination, these riverbeds became the paths of glacial runoff. The longer I stared at Jung’s images, the deeper I realized I had to go. Every view wore down the surface of my first impression. The trickle began within my own projections on the surface of the pages and deepened as I read Jung’s own words and Shamdasani’s academic amplification of the text. In this way, to read *The Red Book* is like working with a dream. The images appear; upon the first light of waking we scramble to affix those amazing images to our memory. By the time we get words on the page to describe, as best we can, what adventures or characters were presented, the stream of projections, analysis, and amplification have already started to pull us back down into the depths from whence the dream arose. What Jung exemplifies in *The Red Book* is the next step, that of active imagination, a conscious attempt to reengage those images from the unconscious. During this process, one sets aside ego control as much as possible to let the archetypal contents speak again in the light of day. We will explore this more as we go along, but for now, let us move from the snowy white of this childlike wonder into the chaos and depths of the unconscious *nigredo*.

DARKENING INTO THE NIGREDO

For the past seven years, the late fall/early winter has been a difficult time for me, emotionally. The day before Thanksgiving in 2013, I received a call that my mother had suffered a brain aneurysm. She had subsequently fallen into a coma and there was little that could be done at the time to address her situation. None of the tests that were run showed pressure in her skull, but her continued unresponsiveness pointed to that being the issue. We were told that all we could do for the time being was wait. So, we waited. As an only child, I went back and forth from her hospital bedside to the store she owned and ran with my father. He and I traded duties, one of us always trying to be with her in case she woke up. Day after day, we worked and waited. The holidays in retail are extremely busy, and with news of her condition spreading, more and more people came by to give us their care and concern, each day bleeding into the next. At first, waiting in the hallway of the hospital, the mechanical blips and beeps even bled into my sleep; then the constant refrains of “no change still,” “no, they don’t know,” “we are still waiting,” haunted even the most mundane tasks.

The days dragged on; Christmas finally arrived. A friend and I managed to at least get a small tree set up at the house and a smaller one in my mom’s hospital room. It was a morose holiday, not knowing if we would ever be able to spend another one with her, and if we did, how much of her would be left to enjoy it. Then the New Year came. Finally, I had to return home. After seven weeks, she still had not awakened from her coma.

When I got home, it snowed. It was the first time I had been able to sit and begin to process what was happening. As the snow fell, I wept. I began to imagine life without my mother: all the things left unsaid, the trips not taken. I began to grieve. The soft snow fell outside and my heart began to crack open. The white facade of that beautiful snowfall put the dark depths of my grief into stark contrast. It had been weighing on me so heavily that it had frozen me in place. I realized that for those many weeks I, too, had been comatose. Of course, not literally, but inside, with every passing day, I froze more and more into a state of despair.

The *nigredo* is a place of death and chaos, as all sits in darkness and churns, waiting to find its way to the light of consciousness, to creation, rebirth. This is where I found myself. With the snow falling around me and tears streaming down my face, I embraced the chaos. I realized that I needed to give up my hopes of ever returning to the way I knew before. This paralysis was a symptom of clinging to what was no longer working for me. I needed to let go, to move toward whatever strange or terrible thing might come. It was better than no movement at all. Even in the Arctic realms, the ice, which seems so solid, moves. We rarely see it or hear it. Those who live in those remote areas may go for long spans of time before noticing a change, but change is happening. The glaciers flow; rivers of ice carve the land, re-shaping these landscapes into their own image. This is what was happening for me. After all those weeks of being frozen in the buzz of daily life, in the quiet of that moment, surrounded by snow, I finally began to thaw.

AS WITHIN, SO WITHOUT

This was not my first encounter with snow and ice reflecting a psychic process. Almost a year before my mother fell into her coma, I viewed the short film *Antarctica* by Robert Romanyshyn (2012). In this film, using still photographs with a voice-over, he documented his own impressions of a trip to Antarctica. As I viewed those images of the ice, I felt a shift in my psyche. Only later did I understand that this was the ice announcing itself as a symbol that would accompany me for years to come. In that moment of viewing, I experienced a similar fresh snowfall moment, much like my first encounter with *The Red Book*. It was as if I had never seen snow or ice before, never viewed a photograph of the Arctic. The images came alive! Afterwards, Romanyshyn, who was presenting his film for viewing, asked us to take a moment and try to recognize “who within us” was viewing this film?

I quieted my senses, secreted myself in a corner of the room, and felt my hands come to my chest in a form of prayer. In that soft place, my mind rushed with all the images of ice, flowing as if from glacial runoff. Then, in an instant, the stream left my mind and flowed down my face. I was weeping. The depths of the grief I felt in that moment for our earth, for that ice, was one that I will never forget and one that I would recognize again a year and seven weeks later. In weeping for my mother, the woman who gave birth to me, I felt a new, deep grief for Mother Earth. This grief, once recognized and honored, was the only way that I could begin to thaw. These tears left bright blue valleys of flowing water in the veins of my frozen heart.

In the same way that I focused on my outward responsibilities, pushing myself beyond my limits during this difficult time, we as a human community are doing the same to our habitable planet. We distract ourselves from the inevitable reality of our current climate situation and satiate our worries with material concerns. As we harden our hearts to the plight of the planet, and the longer those of us who care deeply go

unheard, we begin to freeze in place. With dark seas opening up to a new era of exploration in our materialistic world—that of new fishing lanes and drilling sectors for black gold: oil, the new shining treasure at the top of the world—we must see through this dark temptation to hear the true call underneath.

This burgeoning capitalist call for economic growth potential is threatening the Arctic and our world in more ways than we realize. In our warming climate, the Antarctic ice sheet is melting and cracking, calving massive icebergs into the oceans, inevitably causing sea level rise. At the same time, the ice sheet in Greenland is losing its sheen. It is becoming darker and darker because of soot from the frequent drought-induced forest fires, coal-fired power plants, and the feedback loop that is ongoing and growing. As the ice melts, the water becomes ripe and warm for algae bloom, which in turn darkens the surface of the ice. As the surface darkens, the melt continues to grow, the more ocean water opens up to drills and industry, and the cycle goes on and on, the darkness forever growing: an endless feedback loop.

Here, in this darkness, we can see how important this *nigredo* is, in and of itself, and perhaps it is even more creative than one might think. We can see how, as was cited of Hillman, the *nigredo* is an accomplished step on the journey. Even reaching the *nigredo* is an accomplishment. Once one has been touched by devastation and trauma in one's life or world, they are thrust into the truth of this darkening. From this place, one can either become paralyzed or find another, perhaps less conventional, way through.

Sinking into that grief allowed me the time and space to imagine a new path forward. As I did so, the ice that was encasing my heart began to crack and melt. As I sank into the void, staring into that beautiful snowfall, I found myself on the edge of the world where the ice is melting exponentially, and our world is ever warming. This is a place where there is a constant threat of death, even before our current era. It is a harsh and threatening climate, this *Thule*. So many of those explorers of old never returned from their dark sea voyages, and in the pits of despair it can seem like there is no way out. This realm is the realm of death. The symbol of death is potent in the underworld of the unconscious, but we do not have to die in body to find ourselves there.

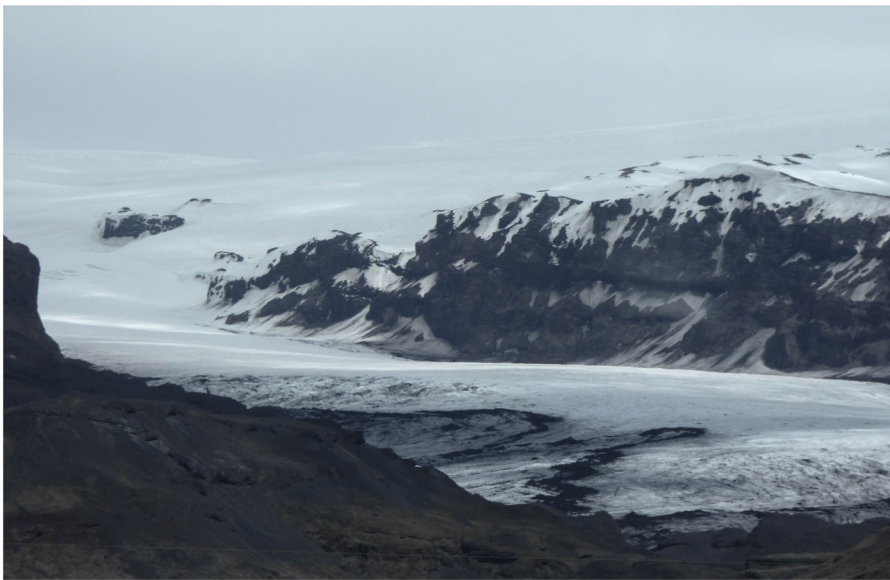


Figure 2. Photograph of an Icelandic glacier, *Where Snow Meets Sky and Turns to Water*, by Sarah D. Norton, 2015.

LEARNING TO DIE AND DIE AGAIN

In *Lament for the Dead*, James Hillman and Sonu Shamdasani, editor of *The Red Book*, discuss a quote from *The Red Book*: “We need the coldness of death to see clearly. Life wants to live and to die, to begin and to end” (Hillman & Shamdasani, 2013; Jung, 2009, p. 266). This quote is in the chapter titled “Death” (pp. 262–268), a fitting place for it. In this chapter, the character of Jung finds himself in a northern land where the gray, hazy, cool air gives way to equally gray clouds that blend seamlessly into a never-ending horizon. It is a lonely scene where everything blurs into one uninterrupted gray landscape.

Here Jung (2009) begins a dialogue with “the dark one” (p. 263), asking to stand near him, this being who, by its own admission, is cold and dead. “I know you are ice and the end,” Jung says; “you are the cold silence of the stones; and you are the highest snow on the mountains and the most extreme frost of outer space. I feel this and that’s why I stand near you” (p. 263). The cryosphere, comprising those places on the planet that are permanently or seasonally frozen, is a place of ice and death. So many explorers have been lost amidst these alluring vistas. In this quote, we see that ice and death are one.

In our world today, this is perhaps more literal than I would intend it to be. However, with the melting of ice and the subsequent changes in ocean temperatures and levels, it shows us how deeply complex this connection is—a complexity that brings us never-ending feedback loops. Those living in low-lying areas are already feeling the effects and loss of this complex system. For others, the threat of further changes places them into a state where death is imminent, at least psychologically if not physically. Many believe we are headed toward an apocalypse. Whether this is the case or not, the truth of our current condition is that life as we know it is gone; we can no longer return to the status quo where we assumed that our human activity was separate from the state of our planet. As the character of Jung stands on the banks of the ocean with the dark one, he witnesses an apocalyptic scene: Hordes of bodies float by; they disappear into the mists beyond, into a “smoky shroud” (Jung, 2009, p. 264). “The word ‘apocalypse’ derives from the Greek *apokalupsis*, a derivative of the verb [meaning] to uncover, to reveal. The Latin renders the word as *revelare*, to unveil, to pull back (*re*) the cover (*vellum*)” (Wilson, 2003, p. 190). In this misty land, these dead disappear beyond the veil or shroud; at the same time, only once the mist has cleared slightly can the dead be seen in this gruesome setting. So we see here Jung in a place of death, surrounded by death, watching the dead float beyond the veil, beyond the funerary shroud, in the company of death. He dies, and dies, and dies again.

This ability is one we all need to learn: to die to life without literal death. In active imagination, the ego must be killed off so that the unconscious can speak without ego’s influence. Of course, as in dreams, this death is not the end, for we always need our ego to negotiate these unconscious energies. Rather, it is a rebirth to a new way of understanding. In this dark place of death and dying, the ego must die and die again to see more deeply into the abyss. By accessing these depths, experiencing this figurative death, our capacity to empathize is expanded.

In this scene, Death is somewhat surprised at Jung. The living are not generally seen in this place. He, of “living matter,” embodied, heavy, cannot be here to stay. He must be here searching for something (Jung, 2009 p. 263). In this moment, we understand that, through an imaginal journey, the body has also come into the realm beyond. This learning is embodied. We must feel it within to truly learn. This seems to be the

way of things; unless we are affected directly, we, as human beings, seem to have a hard time connecting to big ideas like climate crisis.

As Hillman (2016) points out, “Understanding is never a collective phenomenon. It is based on sympathy, on intimate knowledge, on participation. It depends upon a communication of souls” (p. 41). In other words, if we have not been touched personally, have not experienced an extreme weather event, or known someone who has, we seem to have trouble relating to the situation that our world is in today. We have to develop that empathetic view; only by standing close to death in this icy realm can we be reborn to a new way forward.

EMPATHIZING WITH ICE

Once I began to explore the image of ice, I learned that the term scientists have assigned to the reflective nature of ice, snow, and the Arctic is the *albedo*. This alchemical term is used to describe the amount of solar radiation that is reflected into the atmosphere. The higher the *albedo*, the more reflective the surface, the cooler the ice. Projection, in its depth psychological definition, becomes important when imagining this reflective capability of ice. Projection is an unconscious process that occurs when we cannot claim our own unconscious material. Once a particular aspect or energy is rejected, it is displaced onto another, for good or ill. Remember that blanket of snow that we encountered with childlike wonder? Once the black of the *nigredo* begins to seep through, shades of blue and gray begin to form. We see shadows against the light. The unconscious is finding a place to reveal itself to us. If we reject these scenes, no matter how beautiful or terrifying, they take on a life of their own and find a home outside of us.

In our current state of environmental degradation, overuse of fossil fuel, deforestation, microplastic contaminations, and so much more, it is hard to imagine how our psychic state could affect our physical situation. Nevertheless, it does, and deeply. We are slowly committing suicide as a species through our inattention or avoidance of these difficult issues; or worse, through willful ignorance and general disregard for the planet and her people. Hillman (2016) recognized this in *Suicide and the Soul*, when he wrote, “The world is closer to a collective suicide, yes; that this suicide must actually occur, no” (p. 57). Though we are headed in a destructive direction, we do not have to continue on this path. Rather than projecting our suicidal ideations out onto the matter of our world, we must learn to turn that inward, carefully and imaginally, to understand that what needs to die in us is not the totality of our being, but rather the way that we have been doing things up to this point. Our striving ego must set an example and, as in active imagination, step aside to be a willing partner in a process of communication and growth. If we can make this ego sacrifice in ourselves, we can stop projecting it onto the world outside of us.

Often the scientific data is too overwhelming, the grief and hopelessness too much. We want to freeze when confronted with the state of our world today, just as I found myself doing in those difficult weeks of my mother’s illness. I was fortunate enough to return home before I began the difficult process of melting the ice within. However, even before the floodgate of my tears broke, the cracks had begun to show. The hardest part of that time was the not-knowing. The doctors had no answers; there were no signs of recovery; everything seemed to point to an inevitable loss; and yet, there was hope. This hope was both a blessing and a curse in its ambiguity.

TWO SIDES OF AMBIGUITY

For those struggling with ambiguous loss, there is no moment of finality to punctuate the loss, to initiate grieving in a traditional way. In the book, *Loss, Trauma, and Resilience*, marriage and family therapist Pauline Boss (2006) lays out her guide to dealing with families and individuals who are experiencing this unique type of trauma. Ambiguous loss is “an unclear loss that defies closure” (p. xvii). This means that an individual was either lost in body, but is still present psychologically, as in cases of those missing (due to war, mass casualty events, kidnapping, etc.). Or, in the reverse, the body of the individual remains, but all that the individual once was has been lost (as in the case of comas, strokes, Alzheimer’s, addiction, etc.). Either way, a deep tension is felt that must be held.

I experienced ambiguous loss when my mother fell into that coma for seven long weeks after her brain aneurysm. She has, in the years since, recovered almost fully. It was a long and arduous journey, and I could not be more thankful to still have her with us, but that time has left a traumatic mark on my psyche. As mentioned previously, I felt utterly alone during that time and, as the weeks dragged on, I had trouble holding onto hope of her returning. It seemed, at times, that it would have been easier if she had died from her aneurysm. This seems harsh, but in reading Boss’s work sometime later, I found this was not uncommon and I was far from alone in my morbid fantasy. Of course, I felt blessed and lucky, as people reminded me daily while we waited for news of change, but that did not mean that I was not also feeling horrible and cursed, stuck in what felt like *Groundhog Day* (Ramis, 1993).

Each day grinding on, like a great glacier, was slowly crushing my hope of returning to my previous state of relative normalcy. Over time I began to adjust my expectations. The longer she was in the coma, the greater the chance that she would lose some physical or mental functioning outside of the initial damage. I knew that, were she to wake, she would no longer be the mother that I knew before. The longer I waited, the more this seemed okay. I began to grieve even as those around me held onto eternal hope. Instead, I began to revise my expectations that, no matter what happened, my world would never be the same. Even if my mother awakened completely healed and exactly as she had been before, I was forever changing as this process moved on. The glacier in my heart and mind ground me down more and more, day after day, like a mill, refining me, leaving only a white powder of glacial flour in its wake and the landscape forever changed.

Boss (2006) tells us that “the capacity to find meaning in ambiguity requires a systemic both/and approach” (p. 97). This was something I realized on my own and with which I was grappling. When I went home to await more news, the paralyzing hope became too much. I had to grieve. Once my mother awakened, she had to re-learn everything. I was there for her through a lot of the process. At each stage I hit my head against the paradox of grief and hope again and again. There were parts of me, expectations I had, that were dying everyday so the rest of me could live. I was very happy to have her awake and moving, but our roles had now been reversed, if only for a time. I was mothering her. I was there when she took her first painful, nauseous steps. I was there as she remembered to tie her shoes again.

Each moment in this process made me happy and sad. Still, to this day, I struggle with the paradox. I grieve for the time she spent in the coma and the way our relationship has been forever changed. But I still love her as much as I ever have and, in some ways, we are closer than we have ever been. Still, the remnants of grief remain. This pull between two opposing forces in Jungian terminology “is called the ‘tension of opposites,’ wherein something from each pole of the psyche is constellated at one time,

creating new ground” (Estes, 1997, p. 460). This paradoxical, polarizing state eventually has to give. In the tension between the two, a “transcendent third” emerges. This is not one or the other; it is both/and.

This is a hard thing to imagine or to live into, but it is a necessary compromise in the process of coming to terms with ambiguous loss. The not-knowing, the waiting, can paralyze like the ice. Yet, “being able to bend and adapt to situations of ambiguity rather than struggle endlessly for answers can minimize the harmful, immobilizing effects” (Boss, 2006, p. 145). In other words, I had to learn to live in the not-knowing. I had to let go of the possibilities and the past and simply be in the moment. Each day brought a new death, which brought with it life and a new tension to navigate and grow from. Even now, years later, I find I am still growing and learning from this experience. The ambiguous loss that initiated me into this strange grieving process began with those images of ice in our world, briefly contracted to focus on my personal mother, and now encompasses both. The more I sit with this image of ice in the paradoxical waiting, the more I see our world suffering from the same ambiguous loss on multiple fronts.

APOCALYPTIC BLUES

In the apocalyptic year that was 2020, the veil began to lift on many aspects of our society. As I bear witness to our current racial justice issues and our struggles against COVID-19 reflected against the icy backdrop of a changing climate, I know we need to take these lessons in deeply. We need to claim our shadow material and stop projecting it out on others. As the veil is lifted on our deeply flawed institutions, if we have been lucky enough to remain unscathed, we need to imagine that we are also the ones who have lost loved ones to unjust violence or preventable deadly transmission. We need to know that we can be simultaneously outraged and still have hope for a better way forward. We need not cling to the ways of the past, to the way things were before COVID; or before the racism that still clings to our institutions and fellow citizens was broadcast on such a large scale; or before we realized we are using our planet’s resources to the point of no return. We need to sacrifice those hopes that are tied to a “return to normal.”

As more and more people become aware of our flawed systems, a growing pandemic, and the changing climate, the more hope and worry clash. We cannot imagine a way forward so we are stuck in the ambiguity, in the not-knowing. We are lost. There is place for hope, though. This is the gift of ambiguity—that curse that is a blessing. This ambiguous loss has spurred countless protests recently. Protest is good, for “protest is, after all, action, and this is better than remaining immobilized in despair” (Boss, 2006, p. 174). In speaking out against the way we are treating our planet and its people, we are moving from this black-and-white, either/or thinking, from pure hope or pure despair, into a bluer shade of each. As we continue forward, let us be like the ice and hold onto all that blue can give us. In the upcoming *albedo* we must see through to the shades of blue within its depths. We could not know the *albedo* without the *nigredo* that came before. If everything were darkness and despair, we would have no knowledge of life or joy, and vice versa.

If you have ever walked on a large body of ice, or even seen pictures of the Arctic, you were certainly struck, as I was, by the myriad shades of blue these giant “white” bodies of ice reflect (see Figures 1, 2, & 3). This blue is the color of the melt. It is the deep depths of the ice that have been compressed so completely that even the smallest air particle is pushed out. This blue is the blue that brings death to the white ice and shows us the melt as it begins to flow. In my imagination, this blue is the flowing tears which cracked and

melted my frozen heart in those difficult moments, the tears of the ice. The blue ice reminds us that every day should be lived, fully experienced, felt in body and soul.

These multiple shades of blue make up the middle way, teach us that the black-and-white is both/and; there is blue in both, and each must be acknowledged to fully understand the other. This blue mindset that we need to move forward is ambiguous and fluid; it flows and turns, always leaving something behind but always headed toward the collective ocean. It takes us deep into the valley, beyond the apocalyptic veil. It reminds us of the blue necessity of tears. The healing quality of this powerful bodily function makes our emotion tangible and forces us to share these inner feelings outwardly. Tears are love, and grief, and loss, transformed into the physical realm of matter, of the mother. Just as Jung wrote, this realm of the mother is one of endless creativity (Jung, 1980c, p. 79), one that brings together the deepest depths of the unconscious and the highest heights of our imagination.



Figure 3. Photograph of icebergs in Jökulsárlón, the Glacier Lagoon, in southern Iceland. *An Embrace of Scars*, by Sarah D. Norton, 2015.

THE *ALBEDO* OF INDIVIDUATION

Here, after this gift of blue, we find ourselves in the bright white of the *albedo*. Unlike the naïve innocence of freshly fallen snow, this *albedo* is tried and tested. Like

the white upper layers of the glaciers and ice caps, this white has real weight and density. It is pressed and condensed from the trials of the *nigredo*. It has been softened by blue tears and taken on deep shadows of its own. It moves us forward with its weight, chasing out valleys in the landscape; making its presence known for millennia. Here, the light of reflection is not only white, but reflects vibrantly the incoming silvers and golds as well as the rosy glow of the rising and setting sun.

The white quality of this reflected light is not an absence of color; rather, it is the result of every color blending together. Where black absorbs all colors within it, blending them into a dark mass, white reflects a rainbow of colors, blending them all so seamlessly that the eye cannot differentiate between them. This means the *albedo* in its most basic nature is multicolored. The alchemists came to this conclusion as well, connecting the *albedo* with more than just white. Though the alchemists would not have known this connection between *albedo* and future scientific findings of reflectivity, it is fascinating how connected the terms are, even centuries apart. Two of the terms/symbols that alchemists used for the *albedo* are the *omnes colores* (the many-colored) and “the peacock’s tail” (Jung, 1980a, p. 231). It is a unifying white; it is the one made of the many. This quality of connection within ice is very important.

For Jung, the goal of his psychological process and the alchemical opus was to create the gold: the individual who is fully individuated. Jung (1970a) wrote that individuation “is a relatively rare occurrence, which is experienced only by those who have gone through the wearisome but ... indispensable business of coming to terms with the unconscious” (p. 133), inferring the idea that this is a lifelong relationship and that, in truth, the process is more important than the end goal. This seems true for the alchemists as well. The quest to create gold is equally important as the gold itself and, in its own right, returned many valuable scientific results and fascinating writings.

In individuation, a person is intimately involved in an operation of recognizing the unconscious influences coming from psyche and differentiating those from themselves. One stage of this sorting is to reclaim one’s projections. To return these outcast energies home to our conscious awareness can offer a vital clue to other energies we may not be aware of. Only by recognizing and claiming these unconscious shadows can one truly find who one is at their core. Each is a piece of the larger puzzle of the Self. This deep Self, yes, with a capital “S,” is the goal of Jung’s psychology. This is the Philosopher’s Stone, the *lapis*, the gold of the psychological, alchemical opus; the Philosopher’s Stone that gives eternal life to whomever possesses it. The Self, too, is eternal and unmoving. It is unyielding and permanent. This is how most of us thought of the big ice (cryosphere) before the recent era of climactic change.

INDIVIDUATION AS CONNECTION

The opening quote in this paper gifts the next, and possibly most important part of the process of individuation: “it gathers the world to oneself” (Jung, 1970a, p. 136). Being on the path of individuation is an ambiguous journey; there is no end in sight. There may be an ultimate goal, but how to get there needs to be fluid and changeable, like the hope we must harness in an ever-changing and uncertain world. In this icy view of individuation, the world and our place in it is of utmost importance. We have moved into a place of understanding, no longer childlike or unaware that there are big issues to tackle. This understanding brings with it a measure of chaos, trauma, and even death, both figurative and literal. Then, with full knowledge of these dark depths, we must face them. We must own our part in it all and begin to grieve. Only through the

flowing water of understanding can we begin to soften our hearts to the plight of the world around us.

This is the deliberate path of individuation through which we can claim our place, reclaim our unconscious projections, and begin to move forward with renewed hope. This is the goal which avoids the hard cracks and breaks of a sacrifice we did not choose, but which was thrust upon us. In my experience, a willing sacrifice is preferable to a traumatic push over the edge into the icy depths. This latter way can cause the heart to harden and the initial sacrifice of hope is dictated, not chosen. Though there are times when we cannot choose, as in the cases of the large, inevitable issues that face us today, we still have time to adjust our responses to them. Rather than being caught off guard, frozen in place, or brought to fear or anger by our strong emotions, we must travel into the depths to understand the larger meaning and purpose. Though we cannot choose the ultimate outcome, we can make a conscious decision to face *any* outcome fully. We must embrace the unknown with a soft heart, empathy, and ever-renewed hope.

AN ICY MOVEMENT

When I was confronted with that first experience of the Antarctic ice, I began to wonder, why this image, why now? Why was I having such a strong reaction to these images? We live in an era when the issue of climate crisis is gaining traction every day. The images of icebergs floating in a blue, empty sea with a single polar bear struggling for survival were beginning to saturate the environmental narrative. It was so common, in fact, that it was easily dismissed, but there it lurked, under the surface of everything. As the years have passed, the situation has only gotten worse. More and more people are being affected by the constant change. Even if their local environment is relatively stable, their psychic one has been thrown into crisis, whether they are aware of it consciously or not. It is a time of psychic upheaval. The Nordic rune “I,” *isa* or *iss*, means ice. In many interpretations of rune casting, *isa* is said to portend a time of concentration and stillness; indeed this is what *isa* brought to me and what I hope it can offer the Collective.

Though many wars have been fought for less, I prefer to think of the struggle against climate change as a cause for peaceful, steady protest. To save these delicate but towering places on our planet, we must lean into the image of ice. We need to be calm and quiet, steady and immovable in our convictions. We need to make a sacrifice of all that no longer serves, to die to a way of life that puts profit over people or planet. We need to show the importance and immediacy of these concerns through our tears, just as the bright blue of the ice reveals its wounds to us. Through this type of individual sacrifice, we can hopefully create larger movements. Though there will certainly be cracks along the way, a steady expression of grief and concern is the only thing that may begin to melt the ice in our collective hearts and promote the level of empathy needed outwardly, as we continue our inner work. This language of a necessary, willing sacrifice, and the grief that accompanies it, rather than forced compliance, is also one of the few ways we may be able to turn the tide on COVID-19 and systemic injustice.

When I was first confronted by the image of ice, it came in concert with a renewed exploration of *The Red Book*. I felt that the two came hand-in-hand; one prepared me for the other. In similar fashion, the ice and *The Red Book* accompanied me and prepared me for the ambiguous loss and subsequent recovery with my mother. Without the careful guidance of both text and image, I would not have made it through

that difficult time. It seemed that *kairos* was guiding the way, setting the stage for an opportune moment when my inner explorations met my outer trauma and the transcendent third was born. This third thing was a new way of looking at the world, others, and myself, with a bluer eye, an eye ever mindful of the grief and pain of others, a new level of empathy.

MELTING THE ICE IN OUR HEARTS

For years, the Inuit Shaman Angaangag Angakkorsuaq has been spreading what he terms “Ice Wisdom.” He travels all over the world as an emissary from his native Greenland. In this time of pandemic he has even been offering webinars and Zoom consultations. He tells of the melting of the big ice and the tales of his people which have prophesied its passing. In 2010, he led a ceremony with representatives from indigenous tribes all around the globe. In this ceremony, they lit a sacred fire on the big ice of Greenland’s ice cap. This ceremony was meant to mark the passage into a new era, one that was foretold long ago—one that says the big ice will melt, the landscape of the earth will change, even the seasons will be lost, and many will die. This is a frightful prospect, but there is hope. We must learn to melt the ice in the heart of man, he says. “Only by melting the ice in the heart of man, will man have the chance to change and use his knowledge wisely” (Sulzer, 2010, para. 2). This prophecy was passed down to Angakkorsuaq from his grandmother. Once the big ice begins to melt, the story continues, a sacred fire will be lit, and the country will become a rose garden.

In Image 159 of *The Red Book*, there is a beautiful crystalline lattice (Jung, 2009). It is an image that Jung painted from a dream. It is an aerial view of a cityscape, but you would not know it to look at it. In the footnotes beneath the image, editor Shamdasani relays some of the process Jung went through to create this dream image in the book. Apparently he sketched it out and, as he drew and painted the mandala figure in the center—the city—it became a flowering rose made of ruby colored glass (Jung, 2009, p. 418). In this account, the combined magic of the imaginal and creative can be seen. The complex dream image that offered itself to consciousness through the creative, feminine process of painting in *The Red Book* became something new, and blossomed.

This collective image of a city in his dream became the rose of new growth through Jung’s active imagination and painting, a practice which, like alchemy, is “an irrigation of the conscious mind by the unconscious,” and is “related ultimately with the process of individuation” (Jung, 1980b, p. 346). Here, Jung seems to suggest with the term “irrigation” the flowing nature of the unconscious and of active imagination. Consciousness is nourished, irrigated by unconscious contents, just as our hearts are renewed by life-giving waters of empathy. This dream city is concretized in *The Red Book*, and brought new life as a glowing, growing rose pointing to the *rubedo* of the alchemical process.

This reddening, when the metal glows red-hot and can thus be transformed, most often follows the *albedo* and points to something new, like the rosy glow of sunrise. In this instance, it is the transcendent third from the *nigredo* and the *albedo*. While reading *The Red Book*, the rose became the grandmother rose of Greenland in my imagination and, in this one image, the Collective was joined with the individual and pointed to a new path forward: one that offers us a warm, hopeful dawn which could thaw our hearts and allow our tears to flow, gifting us the empathy to connect.

HOPE FOR A NEW WAY FORWARD

Just like the multifaceted images presented in this paper, we too must learn to come together. As in the visions of *The Red Book* and the case of ambiguous loss, healing comes from the creation of community: a community of the unconscious, of humanity, and of the earth. This idea is perfectly reflected in the final image of *The Red Book*. On page 169, Jung painted a sea of faces, all in shades of turquoise blue, resonating our empathetic view. There is every type of face you can imagine: both the living and the skulls of the dead, the unconscious, unclaimed, and left behind. All of them are radiating out from a central crystalline shape. This image is one of community united. The ice crystal shines forth in a rainbow of color, melting the ice in the hearts of man. As we melt the ice in our hearts, we can envision a new hope for the world and begin to develop the empathy needed to connect with others. This new hope is one that leaves the ways we have always known behind, yet honors the ancestors that led the way.

Here, in this fluid space, we can express our grief and reclaim our projections. Here in the *nigredo* we have to die to ourselves and to others, and to the ways that no longer serve. Death is the necessary way, and leads to the birth of a new era, a step into the *albedo* of all that we can be. As we acknowledge the death of the world as we know it, we may no longer see the melting ice, the polar bear on the iceberg, the rising seas, and assume there is nothing we can do. Ice, here, can become a symbol for the Self; it can offer us connection to the world while holding our center steady. It offers us blue, tearful eyes of grief, empathy, and understanding. It helps us to reclaim our projections from others and begin to become who we fully are. It reminds us that, no matter what happens now, it will not be the same, and we cannot be the same. As the ice melts around our hearts, we find renewed hope for a world we have never known but must imagine into being. Only then can we move forward as individuals on this path toward wholeness, gathering the world to us rather than freezing it out.

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